PART III · EXPRESSION · TIPS

When your playing sounds flat

Every note can be right and the music still sound flat. The fix is almost always one sign you read but did not play. Find what you notice, then check that one thing.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
Everything is the same loudness	**the dynamics:** is every sign a different step?	p. 72
The tune sounds choppy	**the slurs:** join every note inside the curve	p. 75
Short notes sound heavy	**staccato** is short, not loud	p. 75
The end feels rushed	**rit. and fermata:** slow little by little, then wait	p. 78
The sound is muddy	**the pedal:** change on each new chord	p. 81
The ornament trips the beat	**the main note** lands on time; practise it slowly	p. 84

Four ways to bring music to life

1. **Sing it first**
   Sing the phrase: your voice shapes it naturally. Then copy your voice on the keys.
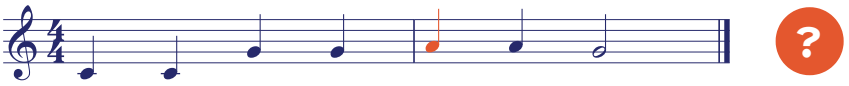
2. **Exaggerate**
   Play the dynamics twice as big as you think. It always sounds smaller to the listener.

3. **Record yourself**
   Listen back with the music: did each sign really happen?

4. **Shape every phrase**
   Grow towards the most important note, then let the phrase fall away.

EXAMPLE

Give this phrase a shape



?

1. **Sing it:** where does it want to go?
2. **Which note** feels like the top of the hill?
3. **Where** would you start soft and end soft?

Start soft, grow to the first A, then fade: **a phrase is a hill**, up and down.

THINK OF IT Expression is the difference between reading a story aloud and telling it.